GLASSHOUSE

THE GAME IS STILL ON

Khela hobe (Game on)' seems to have become West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee's** lucky charm. It was her rallying cry against the BJP in the 2021 assembly polls; she later used the catchphrase for a popular state programme that distributes footballs to local clubs. Now, she wants a special segment showcasing sports-centric films at the Kolkata International Film Festival to be called 'Game On'. The Bengal CM will be hoping the slogan continues to energise party workers, at least till the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Anyway, there's no harm in sending the BJP reminders of their repeated failures to breach her Kolkata fortress.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

THE SPOILS OF PEACE

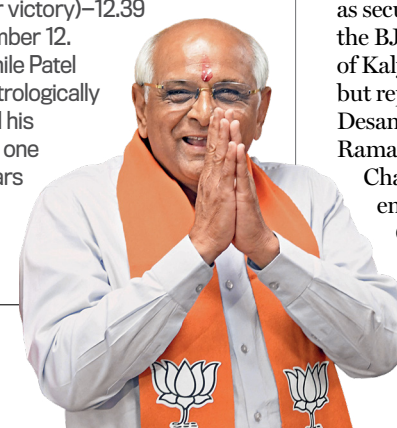


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Mulayam Singh Yadav's brother **Shivpal Yadav** played no bit role in Dimple Yadav's victory in the Lok Sabha byelection in Mainpuri on December 5. The death of the Samajwadi Party stalwart had necessitated the bypoll, and Dimple and Akhilesh Yadav personally visited their uncle to make amends and seek his support. The result was the Yadav bahu's huge win against BJP's Raghuraj Shakya. Speculation is now rife on what the 'return gift' for Shivpal will be: will he be made leader of the opposition in the state assembly or will he get the SP national general secretary's post? Party workers wait with bated breath.

Perfect Timing

Several communities in Gujarat firmly believe in *kamurta*, the inauspicious planetary alignment between December 15 and January 15. The previous two cabinets, in 2012 and 2017, were sworn in during this period and we all know how things panned out for the incumbent chief ministers. Which is why Chief Minister **Bhupendra Patel** was reportedly keen on taking oath not just before the *kamurta* period kicked in, but also at the exact *vijay mahurat* (occasion for victory)—12.39 pm on December 12. However, while Patel may have astrologically force-fielded his government, one hopes his stars stay aligned with the BJP brass too.



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On the Record

Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar** believes media persons have a reasonable understanding of what's happening in the country but are handicapped by Delhiwallas (read the BJP), who tell them "*yahi chhapo, yahi likho* (publish this, write this)". History, however, Nitish feels, will reveal the truth some day as everything is recorded now. "Tomorrow, when their rule is over, the media can always play back these records to show who said or did what," Nitish quipped. Stay tuned.



POWER RIDE

Battleground Andhra Pradesh will soon have an emerald green truck dressed as an armoured vehicle rumbling through the 175 constituencies in the run-up to the next assembly election. Actor-turned-*neta* **Pawan Kalyan** has named it 'Varahi' after the Hindu goddess whose worship weakens the enemy. It will be flanked by ex-army personnel, also in green with red turbans, as security. Varahi may please the BJP, the most likely ally of Kalyan's Jana Sena Party, but replicating what Telugu Desam Party founder N.T. Rama Rao did with his Chaitanya Ratham, an emerald green refurbished Chevrolet van, will be no easy task.

Kaushik Deka *with* ***Romita Datta, Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon, Prashant Srivastava*** *and* ***Jumana Shah***